

Societal Impacts of Data
STAT 184
Professor: Mark S. Handcock

Final Project

Overview

The project can take one of two forms. You should choose one only.

The **first** is to review a topic in the coverage of the class (that is, on societal impacts of data). This topic should extend or expand on a topic covered in the class, but not be just that topic. The report should be stand-alone, starting from the level of the lecture notes and expanding out to review the existing literature on that topic. It need not analyze real data. If you choose this form you must pass the topic by me first by sending me a description in an email, chatting with me after class or coming to my office hours.

The **second** is to write two “Op-Ed” articles one that argues for, *and one that argues against* a position related to the societal impacts of data. For example, the first article could argue that companies has the right to use data they collect on people as they wish. The second article would argue against that position. Another example would be the rise of Big Data means that we do not need theory anymore. You do not need to believe the positions yourself, but you must write two (opposing!) strong “Op-Ed” articles arguing for and against a position. I will give details of what I mean by an “Op-Ed” piece during the lectures.

It is worth thinking about where you will go to after your degree. If it is to graduate school, choose a an issue from the general area where you would like to go. Then you can mention the analysis on your grad school application or to potential employers. Choose an area of interest to you where there are questions that can be answered and are of interest (at least to you).

I do not want a quick and superficial analysis; a good project will show understanding of the issue, and possible solutions.